

ANNA NAGAR

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Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills

This is not an alumni reunion, but more far-reaching than that. Thanks to an initiative by two educators, every Friday evening, Sherwood Hall Senior Secondary School at Harrington Road in Chetpet opens its gates for residents of the neighbourhood to meet up and renew bonds

LIFY THOMAS

Every Friday, between 4.30 p.m. and 6 p.m., the play area at the entrance of Sherwood Hall Senior Secondary School at Harrington Road in Chetpet morphs into a meetup space for those in and around the neighbourhood. After-school activities scheduled to be held in the playground are set aside for the benefit of a small circle of people. They gather under a Copper Pod tree on the campus. They bond over a cup of tea, a few activities, laughter and meaningful conversation. Many of them are seniors, and this initiative is tailored for residents of Harrington Road.

This November, 'Under the Copper Pod Tree', as this initiative is fondly called, will turn one. It was envisioned by Shree Vidya, corres-

pondent of Sherwood Hall Senior Secondary School, along with her friend Kavitha Ray, an independent educator.

For an institution that does not boast a huge space this gesture is noteworthy. According to the school management, the Copper Pod Collective is a space that members co-create. It is a place where people can gather, talk, slow down, and simply be present. Everyone is welcome. No one is outside the circle, and no one has to fit a mould or live up to expectations.

From 10 members at its early meetings, the community has



The playground and (below) from a previous meetup.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

grown to more than 50. Manjula Rajesh, admin manager at the school who is involved in all the nitty-gritty, says they have a WhatsApp group with close to 60 people.

"Before every meetup, we take a poll to see how many will turn up and if they have some expectations. Accordingly we arrange the logistics including chairs, table, green tea and some snacks," says Manjula.

Members take turns to conduct an activity or open up conversations on a topic. Old residents of Harrington Road, talk on food, art therapy, travel tales, a soulful veena recital and so on. Storytelling is a key component of the initiative. Once, members even tried their hand at basketball at the court dedicated to it.

"There is no agenda as such. We just want this to be a place where conversations happen and every individual feels seen, heard and valued," says Manjula, happy with the rich experience she has gained being part of the meetups.

Teachers bring seniors back to school



READERS WRITE

'Open canal in Villivakkam poses a threat'

RAJESH RAMALINGAM

An open water canal which passes through P Block at Agathiyar Nagar 26th Street in Villivakkam is misused to discard waste such as wooden doors and clothes. Further, sewage and industrial effluents are being discharged into it through illegal connections.

The canal in Villivakkam. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

This hampers the flow of water in the canal during rains and cause inundation. Further, the drain being open is a serious concern. In case of waterlogging, the presence of the canal will not be visible and this can cause fatal incidents. In some sections, residents have raised a wall to prevent people from falling into it. However, a larger section of the drain remains open. It may be noted Villivakkam is low-lying and therefore

flood-prone. Water from the nearby SIDCO Nagar is also made to flow through this drain. This drain is important in mitigating inundation in this area but due to its poor upkeep, it poses a threat to people's safety.

Greater Chennai Corporation should take corrective measures before the onset of north east monsoon.

Rajesh Ramalingam is a resident of Villivakkam





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‘Road near Perambur Loco Works railway station waits for mending’



Loco Scheme First Street. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ANOSH NISHTER SADAT

A section of Loco Scheme First Street near Perambur Loco Works railway station is in a bad shape. Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply & Sewerage Board dug up the road a couple of months ago and currently, there is no sign of work.

But the dug-up stretches have been filled with sand, this makes it quite slippery. Things go from bad to worse even with a drizzle. This stretch witnesses heavy traffic during peak hours. Motorists tend to avoid the battered section and drive on the road margin and this exposes pedestrians to the risk of accidents.

Anosh Nishter Sadat is a resident of Thiru Vi Ka Nagar



The park on Perambur High Road - South. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



‘Debris eats into space at Murasolimaran Park’

ALTAR ZACCHEAUS

The Murasolimaran Park (Ward 74, Zone 6 - Thiru Vi Ka Nagar) on Perambur High Road - South (near Mangalapuram) has a dedicated badminton court. However, there is a need for an additional court.

So, regular visitors were using another part of the park to play badminton by cleaning it and

keeping the surface even.

But, this area cannot be used any more. A makeshift shed has been put up here. Further, discarded benches, logs, and other kinds of discards have been dumped. Visitors are unable to use this space.

Visitors request the officials of the Zone 6 - Thiru Vi Ka Nagar of the Greater Chennai Corporation to do the needful.

Altar Zaccheus is a resident of Perambur

You can be our volunteer writer



Dear readers, you can be our volunteer writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number.

‘Pigs roam free in West Gopalapuram’

C. SRIDHAR KUMAR

Solid waste management is poor at West Gopalapuram, a neighbourhood at Pattabiram in Avadi Corporation.

The problem is quite conspicuous at Fifth Street and Sixth Street.

The place is unhygienic, fly-blown and stinks. Residents are unable to keep their windows

open. Now, it has become a serious concern because the waste pileups are drawing a good number of pigs, a carrier of zoonotic diseases.

In an environment of poor sanitation marked by waste pileups, open drains and water-logging, pigs can come in contact with dangerous pathogens and cause diseases.

Further, roaming of pigs on the roads, raises the risk of road accidents.

C. Sridhar Kumar is a representative of Pattabiram Gopalapuram Makkal Seva Sangam, a residents welfare association.



West Gopalapuram in Avadi. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Geopolitics in a tea cup



In addition to the unique flavours that teas from the Government-run TanTea plantations and factory in The Nilgiris bring to the cup, the lingering taste comes from what the initiative represents: helping Tamil repatriates from Sri Lanka, from the 1970s onwards. T. Arunkumar who runs a TanTea dealership with three outlets in Chennai, along with his father S. Thiruvassagam, on the heady combination of empowerment and tea tasting

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

A sprinkle of TanTea retail tea shops operate across Tamil Nadu, largely run by distributors of Tamil Nadu Tea Plantation Cooperation Limited, shortened to TanTea. In Chennai, habitués of Mylapore have likely noticed a TanTea shop abutting the Kapaleeswarar temple tank on RK Mutt Road. If they have not, they cannot be a habitué of that part of town, as this outlet pitched tent there nearly 11 years ago.

And it is likely that even the habitués of that area are unaware that those teas sold in cups as well as in packets in cover designs befitting a brand have a connection with the TanTea headquarters and factory on Orange Grove Road at Conoor. The packets are shipped from there. The odds are even lower that they know that tea plantations in The Nilgiris that follow the clonal plantation model support the making of those teas. And it is even more likely that they do not know that “kindness” is an ingredient that went into the establishment of TanTea. When it was established in 1968 under the Chief Ministership of C.N. Annadurai, it was known as Government Tea Project. From the 1970s onwards, the Tamil Nadu Government had kept these plantations going to support Tamil repatriates from Sri Lanka, providing

them with livelihoods linked to the maintenance of the plantations and the production of teas. Reportedly, the initiative received a huge impetus from M.G. Ramachandran during his terms as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu as he viewed it as a vehicle delivering justice to uprooted Sri Lankan Tamils.

These are the factors that make what swirls in that cup at a TanTea

outlet special, of course in addition to the unique flavours and taste those teas bring to the teapot.

The Mylapore outlet is run by a TanTea dealership, Giri and Co, whose reins are wielded by the father-son duo of S. Thiruvassagam and T. Arunkumar. They have two other outlets, one at Kotturpuram on Gandhi Mandapam Road, inside the CM’s Call Centre premises,

widely known as Government Data Centre, and the other at the Kilambakkam Bus Terminus; both outlets are of recent mint, having been established in 2025 and 2024 respectively.

Of the three outlets, the one at Mylapore is an outlier in terms of operational timings. It functions 24 hours, except from a break between 1.30 a.m. and 3.30 a.m., with

workers employed on a shift system. The outlet at Kotturpuram functions more like a canteen, the eats varied and meant to be more filling as students from the Anna University nearby as well as those from the Madras School of Economics, located behind the Government Data Centre, step in regularly in addition to the general crowd. On why run a TanTea outlet when fresh competition is always brewing in the tea drinking market, a new chain of pocket-sized tea shops always appearing on the horizon from nowhere, Arunkumar remarks it is partly because of the history of empowerment that goes with the brand, and in part due to the unique appeal those teas make to taste buds.

Arunkumar believes that once the customers taste it, the product speaks for itself. And Arunkumar lines up impressive numbers in terms of footfall for the three outlets, each of which offers eats from its kitchen to go with a range of TanTea teas, including what he calls the latest sensation, fruit and flower teas. The milk tea however remains the major grosser.

From his experience, the tea cup at his TanTea outlets is a leveller, bringing students, corporate employees, auto drivers and bus drivers and conductors, among others, to the same table. He was making a specific reference to the outlet on RK Mutt Road near the Mylapore temple tank: “before Metro Rail work arrived in this area, MTC buses would be parked on RK Mutt Road along the temple tank, and the bus crew would park themselves at the outlet for steaming cups of tea.”

Relationship with Mylapore extends beyond commerce and encompasses community. Arunkumar observes that for nearly a decade, the shop joined the 63 Nayanmars festival at the Kapaleeshwar Temple by ensuring free supply of cool drinks, hot teas and coffees, snacks and even packed cooked rice varieties for four days, serving around 400 people each day. Arunkumar notes his outlets at Mylapore and Kotturpuram have drawn celebrities from within the city, cricketer Sri Sudharshan’s visit being etched in his memory. The photo he clicked with the batsman is a proud possession in his mobile storage folder.

(Clockwise from top): TanTea outlets in Kotturpuram, Kilambakkam and Mylapore.



Award ceremony today at Gopalapuram

Vidhya Seva Samman is a initiative of Mission Guru Devo Bhava in association with Lions Club of Meenambakkam and Vedritam Group (formerly DAV Group, Chennai). The initiative aims to honour teachers who have gone beyond the classroom, inspired their students, nurtured values and made a genuine difference to their lives.

The 10 teachers who will be receiving the award on September 6 are: Kala Raman from P.S. Higher Secondary School, Mylapore; Thanukrishnan J. from Smt Durgadevi Choudhary Vivekananda Vidyalaya Senior Secondary School, Kolathur; Shalika Banu from Fathima Central Senior Secondary School; G Sripriya from Motilal Fomra Sanatana Dharma Higher Secondary School, Sowcarpet; J. R. Lakshmi Kantham from The Children's Garden Higher Secondary School, Mylapore; K. Revathy from Chennai Higher Secondary School, Alwarpettai; Janaki G. from Lady Sivaswami Ayyar Girls Higher Secondary School, Mylapore; Sujatha Mukundan from Shri Natesan Vidyasala Matriculation Higher Secondary School; Seema Madan from Kola Saraswathi Vaishnav Senior Secondary School; and R. Subramanian from Govt. Model School, Nandanam.

S. Gurumurthy, columnist and editor of Thuglak will be the chief guest at the award function happening on September 6 at DAV Girls Senior Secondary School in Gopalapuram from 10.30 a.m. onwards.

Anil Khicha, co-founder, Mission Guru Devo Bhava, says they received 217 nominations out of which 185 applications were screened by a team of seven screening committee members who shortlisted 20. These finalists were further assessed by an eminent panel of jury who selected 10 for the Vidhya Seva Samman.

The jury included V. Nandakumar, educationist; V. Kamakoti, director, IIT-Madras; Dr Sudha Seshayyan, former vice-chancellor, Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University; and Gopal Agrawal, philanthropist.

Mapping lessons beyond the classroom

A geography teacher from the Government Model Higher Secondary School in Nandanam bagged two awards

LIFY THOMAS

With two awards, it was double the delight for this Geography teacher from Government Model Higher Secondary School in Nandanam, on September 5 when he received the Dr. Radhakrishnan Best Teacher Award from the Tamil Nadu government. And on September 6, the post graduate teacher will be among ten teachers to receive the Vidhya Seva Samman.

Following teaching stints in Ethiopia and a few Indian states, 12 years ago, R. Subramanian eased into the role as government school teacher at KLK Boys Higher Secondary School in Gummidipoondi.

One would have expected the teacher to face a huge culture shock moving to a geography that hugely contrasts with the one he previously operated in, but that was not the case. "From the word

R. Subramanian (third from left) conducts the morning assembly at the school; and with students at the garden on the campus they take care of.

go, it was smooth sailing at this school in Tiruvallur district. I am good in classroom management and have also prepared modules to train teachers," he says.

Since 2017, Subramanian has been associated with the school in Nandanam. He worked on bringing about behavioural changes in teenagers. He believes that life's most

important lessons are best taught beyond the four walls of the classroom. Be a friend to teenagers, not just their teacher, he says.

A tree planting exercise he initiated on the school campus was much appreciated.

"Engaging students in activities such as nurturing saplings and painting the walls of the school

with social message are a few ways I built a rapport with students who would otherwise skip classes," says the 54-year-old teacher who is a resident of Madipakkam.

One of the Subramanian's pet initiatives is anchoring the morning assembly, where relevant news in science and technology or current affairs is presented to students in a capsule format through stories or Thirukkural. This is followed by a question and answer session where students giving the right answer are given goodies by the school headmistress.

Beyond the classroom, the "geography sir" is a resource person with the School Education Department on school safety, a visiting faculty for civil service coaching at Anna Institute of Management in Greenways Road and a trainer at Naan Mudhalvan Competitive Exams programme.

In most institutions with higher secondary classes, science and commerce are preferred groups for

students. Subramanian has been changing this thinking in students by providing them with an understanding of careers in UPSC and TNPSC.

He says: "History, Geography and Economics are among core subjects in civil service examination and focussing on them is essential."

Seven months pregnant and on the podium

After 22 years of dedication to the craft of karate, recognition at the national level arrives at an unlikely time for V. Anitha

B. PRABHU

“V. Anitha from Chennai bags gold in KATA at an All India Karate Championship.” As the reader would note, that is a regular like one taht jumps at them every other morning from newsprint.

Read the now bolstered with other details that went with that achievement.

“V. Anitha, 30 years old, a resident of Ramapuram in Chennai, bags gold in the Individual Kata competition at the All India Karate Championship held at Vatakara in Kerala, on August 29 and 30, 2026. And she was seven months pregnant.”

The two-day championship, conducted by Alan Thilak Karate School, drew the participation of more than 1,500 students across categories for men and women. The Kerala team won the overall championship title and the Tamil



V. Anitha. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nadu team secured second place.

Anitha could head to that championship clearly because her family, particularly her husband Prithviraj, backed her in that decision; but the larger motive power that got her there, and eventually onto the podium, is the sense of practising karate, in the competitive arena and outside.

Anitha began learning karate when she was studying in Class III, actively participating in competitions and winning several prizes

even in her school days. When she was in Class X, she faced opposition from her family regarding her decision to persist with karate. However, she remained determined, won her family over to her point of view and continued her training.

She later joined SIET College and completed her B.Com degree. She subsequently worked with Larsen & Toubro (L&T) and other corporate organisations. Although she had established a career in the corporate sector, karate remained her



lifelong passion. She eventually made a conscious decision to leave her corporate career, not because of work commitments, but because she wanted to make karate her “profession and purpose in life” and use what she had learned to contribute to society.

A major influence throughout her journey has been her guru, Hanshi A. Appuraj, an 8th Dan

Black Belt with more than 40 years of experience in karate. A national champion in 1996, Hanshi A. Appuraj has trained more than 10,000 students and continues to guide karate practitioners as an instructor of Alan Thilak Karate School. Anitha has trained under his guidance for more than 22 years, making his mentorship an integral part of her journey.

Anitha's training under Alan Thilak Karate School, founded by **Dai Sensei Moses Thilak**, has also been an important part of her martial arts career. The legacy of the institution is now being carried forward under the technical leadership of **Sensei Neil Moses** and other senior technical directors.

Over more than two decades, Anitha has built an impressive competitive record. She has been a Thiruvallur District Women's Category Champion for more than 10 years, along with several achievements at the State and National levels. She has participated and won medals in numerous district, state and national-level championships. In February 2026, she also secured a medal at the State Championship.

Her achievements have extended beyond the competition arena. She received the Young Achiever Award from the Department of Commerce at SIET College**, recognizing her accomplishments and contribution.

After choosing karate as her profession, Anitha began using her experience to empower others. She currently works as a 5th Dan Black Belt, Karate master, self-defence coach and personal safety strategist. She conducts martial arts, self-defence and personal safety programmes for women employees in corporate organisations, college students and school girls.

In 2024, Anitha married Prithviraj, who has continued to support her karate journey and goals, chief among them is empowering women with self-defence training.

Don Bosco wins inter-school cricket tourney



Don Bosco defeated Heartfulness (Omega) by 23 runs in the final of the Heartfulness Omega Coaching Beyond u-14 inter-school cricket tournament held recently.

The scores (final): Don Bosco 215/7 in 50 overs (Jaikrishwin 44, Saif Ali 35, Sarvesh 34) bt Heartfulness International School Omega NIOS 192 in 48.2 overs (Aadil Asrani 58, Ishaan

Krishnan 35, Prithvin Prem 41).

Special Awards

Man of the match: G. Sarvesh (Don Bosco MHSS); Emerging player of the match: Aadil Asrani (Heartfulness International School Omega NIOS); best batsman: Aadil Asrani (Heartfulness International School Omega NIOS); best bowler: Bragdeesh Aditya (St. John's Public School); best fielder: Smaran Vithlani (Heartfulness International School Omega NIOS); best wicket-keeper: Aswin Srikanth (St. John's Public School); emerging player of the tournament: V. Sachin (St. Bede's AIHSS); most valuable player of the tournament: Prithvin Prem (Heartfulness International School Omega NIOS).

Two-day event to showcase technical skills



AMS College of Engineering conducted an event called AMS - Hackathon 2026. It is a two-day event which aimed to provide students an opportunity to demonstrate their innovation and technical skills.

The hackathon was inaugurated by H. Mohamed Salegh, secretary and correspondent, AMS Group of Educational Institutions. Around

450 students participated, says a press release.

Victor Sundaraj, associate vice-president, Infosys Ltd., Bengaluru, was the chief guest at the valediction. He appreciated the students for their innovative ideas and technical capabilities and encouraged them to continue developing technology-driven solutions, adds the press release.

Sports event for students with hearing impairment

KRM Public School organised a sports event for the students of Dr. M.G.R. Home & Higher Secondary School for Hearing and Speech Impaired Children. According to a press release, the event was held to observe the birth anniversary of Maj. Dhyani Chand.

They were received by the school band and a welcome drill.

Athletic events included: 200 m, 400 m, long jump, and shot put. Team events included: kabaddi and football.

Students of KRM Interact Club of the school sponsored the event, adds the press release. Students of the club spent towards buying medals and certificates and also for lunch and refreshments.

Alumni association launches digital platform

The Alumni Association of Sri Ramachandra Institute of Higher Education & Research launched its digital alumni engagement platform recently. According to a press release, it is supported by a software called AlmaShines.

The event witnessed the participation of around 500 alumni from various batches. Three distinguished alumni took part as special guests. They are: Dr. Haripriya Aravind, Head of Cataract and IOL Services,



Aravind Eye Hospital, Chennai; Dr. Saveetha Rajesh, Director, The Pupil International School and NMV University, Chennai; and Dr. Yashwanth Kumar V., Honorary Consul of the Republic of El Salvador.

On the occasion, the as-

sociation awarded scholarships to meritorious students.

The platform was inaugurated by SRIHER chancellor V.R. Venkatachalam in the presence of trustee Samyuktha Venkatachalam, adds the press release.

CII's youth wing conducts competitions



Young Indians - Chennai Chapter, a wing of the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) hosted its "Chennai Chapter Round of Future 6.0, Yi YUVA's national Youth Policy & Solutions Platform" at Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology recently. According to a press release, the event is all about providing a platform to showcase youth-led solutions to India's pressing challenges.

The Chennai edition saw participation of 129 teams. After multiple screening stages, approximately 90 semifinalist teams were narrowed to 40 finalists competing in the city finals. Teams worked on following sectors: health, accessibility, road safety, and climate change, adds the press release.

Social Work students conduct camp at Attrambakkam

The Department of Social Work of Women's Christian College, Nungambakkam, organised a rural camp for first year post-graduate students at Attrambakkam village in Thiruvallur.

According to a press release, events to spread awareness on breast and cervical cancers were conducted.

A lecture was conducted by Dr. R. Fathima Hasan, Professor and Head, Department of Obstetrics & Gynaecology, Government Medical College & Hospital, Thiruvallur.

In her address, she stressed on early detection and healthy food habits. She also advised the women to be attentive to changes in their bodies and seek timely medical guidance.

There was a session on menstrual hygiene. Sanitary napkins, provided by Naalaya Sarithiram Trust, were distributed to the women of Attrambakkam village, adds the press release.

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Health camp for police personnel

Vinita Multi-Speciality Hospital organised a medical camp for police officers and their families at Cochin House Police Quarters in Thousand Lights West. According to a press release, the camp was organised to recognise the service of the police personnel to protect the city and therefore no fee was charged.

The inauguration was attended by V. Jayachandran, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Triplicane; P. Ponraj, Assistant Commissioner of Police, Nungambakkam; Subbumari Valavan, Assistant Commissioner of Police, Quarters & Welfare; and E. Ramasundaram, Inspector of Police, Nungambakkam.

The camp was organised under the leadership of Vinod K. Dasari, Chairman, Vinita Hospital, and Dr. Sarita Vinod, Managing Director, Vinita Hospital.

Tests were conducted for various ailments. A total of 129 people including police personnel and their family members attended the camp. Also, there was a training programme on cardiopulmonary resuscitation for police officers. The camp underscored the importance of preventive health-care, adds the press release.



During the event. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Awareness programme on infant health

In observance of World Breastfeeding Week, Goodwill Trust, Alliance Club of Chennai Super Kings, and Nature Research Foundation jointly organised an awareness programme at the ICDS Centre, Padipudu Nagar.

According to a press release, expectant mothers and Anganwadi staff took part.

The session was handled by Ally. Dr. Bharathi Natesan. In her address, she stressed on exclusive breastfeeding for immunity of the infant.

She also pointed out workplaces and public spaces need to have a facility for lactating mothers. She also explained about the nutrition of millet-based foods.

Gifts were presented to participants who actively took part in the interactive session.

Goodwill Trust also conducted another awareness programme at UPHC in Ayanavaram.



Speakers club to meet today in Perambur

Perambur Speakers Gavel Club, a unit of Toastmasters International, is conducting its meeting on September 6 at Lane Consultancy, Second Floor, Perambur. Time: From 2 p.m. to 4 p.m. According to a press release, the session is meant for those aged from 10 to 18 years. According to a press release, the programme will be of interest to those who want to improve their communication and leadership skills. The activities include: prepared and impromptu speaking activities. No fee will be charged to take part in the session. For details, call 9495167066

Support group for elders starts its Anna Nagar wing



Time Bank of India, a support group for senior citizens, organised an event at Tower Park in Anna Nagar on the occasion of Independence Day. The event marked the commencement of the Anna Nagar wing of Time Bank of India, says a press release. The idea is to help elders who are living alone by giving them company and accompanying them to doctors, places of worship, and parks without charging any fee, adds the press release. For details, call 99403 91131 / 93810 12117 / 88258 83059 / 87549 10111.

Workshop on making cookies

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on making cookies on September 10. According to a press release, the training programme will focus on making cookies from millets, heirloom rice varieties, and dry fruits. Another workshop on soap making will be held on September 11. The programme will focus on making soaps from extracts of herbs, flowers, leaves, and fruits. Both the sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate (opposite CIPET), Guindy. For registration and other details, call 044 - 29530048.

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